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E3 Reading – Exam Prep Lesson 3: Ordering tasks and a timed practice paper – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to put events in time order, put words in alphabetical order to the third letter, and complete a full paper under exam conditions. This covers AC1.2 and AC4.1 and rehearses all seven criteria.

Materials: Handouts 3A and 3B, one per learner. Handout 3C, the practice paper, one per learner. The 15 word cards from 3B, section 2, written large on A5 paper.

Activity 1: What happened first? (25 minutes, teacher-led then pairs)

1. Tell the class a 30-second story about your morning, out of order: “I got to college at nine. Before that, I missed my bus. After I woke up, I could not find my keys.” Ask what happened first. Let them work it out.
2. Board the time words learners heard, then add more: *first, then, next, after that, later, finally, before, after, when, by September*. Mark *before* and *after* in a different colour. These two cause most of the mistakes.
3. Write: *Before breakfast, she washed the uniform.* Ask which came first, breakfast or washing. Establish that the first event in the sentence is not always the first event in time. Repeat with: *She phoned the school after she arrived.*
4. Hand out 3A. Learners read the short text and number the events alone.
5. Pairs compare, then check together. For each event, ask for the time word that proves its place.
6. Teach the exam routine: underline every date, month and time word in the text first; number the events lightly in pencil; then check that the first event given in the exam matches your order.

Activity 2: Alphabetical order to the third letter (20 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Give five learners the set 1 word cards. They stand in alphabetical order at the front. The class corrects them.
2. Repeat with set 2, where all the words start with *c*. Ask how to decide. Elicit: look at the second letter. Write the words in a column on the board and circle the second letter of each.
3. Repeat with set 3, where all words start with *st*. Circle the third letter. For *stall* and *station*, go to the fourth letter.
4. Teach the paper method for the exam: write the alphabet across the top of the page; cross off each word as you use it; count that you have five words at the end.
5. Learners complete 3B alone, writing the words in the empty tables. Check in pairs, then on the board.

Activity 3: Timed practice paper (45 minutes)

1. Set the room for an exam: desks apart, phones away, no talking. Explain that the real paper allows 60 minutes for a similar text. Today they have 40 so that there is time to review.
2. Hand out 3C. Remind learners of the order to work in: read the title and the first sentence of each paragraph; read the whole text once; then answer.
3. Write the finish time on the board. Give a warning at 20 minutes and at 35 minutes.
4. Do not help with vocabulary. Note which questions individuals get stuck on. This tells you what to revisit.
5. Fast finishers check each answer by finding the supporting line and writing the paragraph number beside it.

Activity 4: Prove it (20 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Learners swap papers and mark in a different colour as you go through the answers.

2. For each question, do not give the answer yourself. Ask one learner for the letter and a second learner for the line in the text that proves it.
3. For questions 2 and 6, ask which wrong option tempted people and why it is wrong. For question 3, write the months on the board in a line and place each event under its month.
4. Take a show of hands for each question to see who got it right. Record the two weakest questions for the class.
5. Each learner writes a personal target on the top of the paper: “Next time I will…”

Activity 5: Exam day routine (10 minutes)

1. Elicit and board a five-step routine: read the title; read the first sentences; read everything once; answer the easy questions first; check each answer against the text.
2. Tell learners there are no marks lost for a wrong answer, so they should never leave a question blank.
3. Learners copy the routine onto the back of their practice paper to keep.

Answer key, Lesson 3

- **3A:** got out of bed 1; washed a shirt 2; ate breakfast 3; left her son at school 4; the bus stopped working 5; phoned the school 6.
- **3B:** Set 1: bus, garden, hostel, market, teacher. Set 2: canal, card, class, college, cycle. Set 3: stall, station, stop, street, student.
- **3C:** 1 B. 2 B. 3 asked for permission 2, took the rubbish away 3, put seeds into boxes 4, snails destroyed plants 5, shared food 6. 4 C. 5 A. 6 B. 7 flowers, food, garden, greenhouse, group. 8 B. 9 C. 10 snails ate the plants; there was no rain for three weeks.
- **Criteria covered by 3C:** Q1 AC1.3, Q2 AC1.1, Q3 AC1.2, Q4 AC3.1, Q5 AC1.4, Q6 AC2.1, Q7 AC4.1, Q8 AC1.4, Q9 and Q10 AC3.1.